WORKSHEET · LEADING DESIGN · BUILDING A DESIGN TEAM

Team Shape and Capability Worksheet

Decide what the team needs to become before you decide who to hire.

How to use it. Fill this in with your own leader or product partner before you open a requisition. Sections 1 to 3 describe the team you need. Sections 4 to 6 turn that into decisions.

1. The vision we are building toward

What leadership wants design to be in the next twelve to twenty-four months
Ask them. Write it in their words, not yours.

The business and product bets the team must support
Where will the organisation put its effort?

What would be different if the team succeeded
Two or three things someone outside design would notice

2. The work the team will do

AREA OF WORK	SHARE OF EFFORT TODAY	SHARE IN TWELVE MONTHS	SKILLS IT NEEDS

3. Skills: broad or deep

For each capability, mark the depth you need (1 aware, 2 working, 3 strong, 4 leads others) now and in twelve months, then who has it today.

CAPABILITY	NEED NOW	NEED IN 12 MONTHS	WHO HAS IT TODAY	GAP
Research and discovery				
Interaction and service design				
Visual and brand craft				
Content and conversation design				
Prototyping and testing				
Design systems				
Data and AI fluency				
Facilitation and storytelling				

Look at the pattern. Mostly 2s across the board is a broad team. A few 4s and many 1s is a deep one. Neither is wrong, but the team should be one on purpose.

4. The shape of the team

Roles we have
By level and capability

Roles we need
What is missing for sections 1 to 3

Where we depend on partners
Product, engineering, data, research, design systems

5. Culture on purpose

A team has a culture whether or not you design one. Name it, so you can hire for it and protect it.

Three behaviours we want to be known for
Specific enough to observe

How they show up in daily work
Meetings, critique, handoffs, how we disagree

What we will not accept
Be honest about what you have tolerated

6. Sequence the hires

ROLE OR CAPABILITY	WHY NOW	HIRE, GROW OR BORROW	BY WHEN

> Take the first hire from this page into the Role Definition Worksheet. Come back to this page every six months. The team you need changes as the work does.